

Online and digital identities

What we think of as ourselves has become complicated by what we see in the online world. There have always been many “selves” within each person; the internet simply makes this obvious.

Identities

There are many elements to someone’s identity: the self at home, the self at school or at work, the self as son or daughter, or as parent, or as employee. These “selves” are the basis for how people lead their lives, and who they interact with, and how they do it. They are also crucial for self-esteem and psychological well-being. Some may find it surprising that these factors have been imported into the virtual world.



△ What’s an online identity?

An online identity is who we present to the online world. It is the person we curate, cultivate, and project in our digital interactions.



△ What’s a digital identity?

A digital identity is the set of identifiers used by organizations to authenticate who we are, so we can access their services.

SEE ALSO

Being a digital citizen	182–183 >
What is social media?	194–195 >
Social media platforms	196–197 >

LINGO

Useful terms

Avatar: The virtual representation of the self, usually in visual form.

Authentication: The act of verifying a person is who they say they are, usually through a password.

End-User License Agreements (EULA): A legal agreement between a software developer or seller and the user.

IRL: In real life.

Meatspace: A term for the offline world.

Namespace collision: When the same concept is understood differently by two groups.

Profile: The public face we project to the online world.

Early online identities

The internet allows users to control the kind and amount of information that they share with others. This was especially true in the early days of online communication, when sending images, audio, and video took a lot of time. As a result, a user could only rely on what another user said about themselves as context for online interactions, which led many people to experiment with their online identities. As the internet has evolved, there has been a shift towards less experimentation and more self-presentation, especially with the advent of social media.

▷ A/S/L

In early chatrooms, when text-based communications started linking strangers, it was hard to know how to interact. A shortcut identity identifier emerged: A/S/L, or Age/Sex/Location.

